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Original Page: 296**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1966**Coverage Date:** 1958-1966**Place Coverage:** G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana**Section Title(S):** Opportunism, Cohesion, And Information

This is a neat way of conforming to Ashby's law of requisite variety, which states that the variety of alternative control actions that a regulating device is capable of must be at least equal to the variety of fluctuations and deviations produced by that which is controlled — a regulating system must be able to generate as many states as can the system that it controls (Ashby, 1956:202–218). The organizational capacity generated by the household-in-community is at least equal to the increment in variety in behavior occasioned by its joining the community. It will be appreciated that the inclusion of additional households gives scope for behavior that would not be possible in a smaller social circle. Complexity and variety increase most rapidly in the approximate range of three to six households and then more slowly as the relative significance of each further addition to the community diminishes.

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Organizational capacity generated by the household-in-community is manifested not only in political processes but also in such aspects as the activities of joking relatives, in exorcising dances, and in the operation of other means of social control. In this context joking relatives function as feedback loops that provide an individual with information about others' reactions to his behavior, reducing randomness both in his behavior and his anticipation of its social consequences. The avoidance/respect relationship is narrower in scope, having smaller propensity for negative feedback than there is between joking partners, but, particularly in regard to prestigious avoidance/respect relatives, there is a good deal of positive feedback. Both the exorcising dance and joking relationships have a rather unusual information function in erasing, as well as countering, entropy in the social system. What I mean by erasure is that both serve to diminish resentment (which I see as entropic) of others' offenses by redefining the situation or by directing resentment to harmless dissipation outside the social system. The exchanges of joking partners include opportunity for making amends and for

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extending forgiveness, which, because it is a public performance, gives emotional  297 comfort not only to the partners but to the whole band as well. Successful exorcising dances remove the bitterness of others' misdeeds by expelling "G//amama's evil."

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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